

No. 758, February 2013

Vertigo

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club
Wellington Section

www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz www.facebook.com/nzacwellington



High Alpine Skills Course
Image courtesy of Sharron Came

Next section night: 11 February, 2013

Annual summer barbecue at Fergs

Its that time of year again for the Wellington section's annual BBQ at Fergs Rock & Kayak!

If you're new to the club then its a great time to come down and introduce yourself to other members. If you've been with the club for a while, then its time to pull out those epic tales of first ascents and massive one-arm dynos!

In general, its a fantastic time to just shoot the breeze and have a good ole' chin-wag, maybe even touch base with potential new climbing partners.

Anyway, come down and grab a free feed and beverage. We are catering for both meat maniacs and veggie lovers.

WHEN: Monday 11th February from 6pm onwards

WHERE: Fergs Rock & Kayak, Shed Six, Queens Wharf

Hope to see you all there.



Club nights are at the Tararua Tramping Club clubrooms, on the second unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea & coffee afterwards.

Section Trip Report – Wharepapa South, 14-16 December 2012

Bridget Janse

Trip participants: Kim Farrar, Rob Dudley, Shna Galindo Juárez, Rini Sugianto, Katy Teasdale, ShiChang Hou, Gemma, Sharon Nicholas, Bridget Janse.

Sitting at a Wellington Section committee meeting I volunteered to organise a section rock climbing trip to Wharepapa South in my spare weekend in December. I really hoped the weather was going to co-operate. Having never organised a section trip before it took a bit of emailing back and forth to the other committee members to find out what paperwork was involved. There are trip form templates and so it was relatively straight-forward once I knew what I had to do – fill in the appropriate trip details and information and email it out.

After what seemed like an endless stream of emails in the weeks and days leading up to the actual trip, three car-loads left from Wellington on the Friday night, about an hour apart. A good food stop was had in Taihape, with a petrol refill in Taupo. My carload arrived at Bryce's around 8.30pm and we set up in the bunkroom. Car number two arrived about 9.30pm. At 10.30pm I was getting a little worried that "little red" car hadn't arrived. Sharon and I went for a drive (as the cell phone reception is somewhat patchy) and when we returned at 11pm, all had arrived. Phew! Lesson number one – when driving to Wharepapa South for the first time ensure you have a good map and clear instructions as things look different in the dark!

Saturday morning dawned fine and beautiful. When ShiChang arrived from Auckland, Sharon and I did a refresher on putting on harnesses, tying into the rope, belaying and climbing calls in the bouldering cave at Bryce's, as there was a diverse range of experience and I wanted to ensure we were all on the same page. We headed off to Froggatt Edge to explore the rock. Sharon and I set up several top ropes throughout the morning on Honeycomb Wall, The Moon Boulder and The Bits. Those that were inclined got into some leading as well. It was nice and relaxed and once people had worked their fingers, feet and forearms and the temperature was climbing we moved around to the right hand side/end of Slug Wall, as another group from Auckland had "laced" most of the climbs on the left. A gentle breeze kept some of the sweat at bay, but many sought shade when they weren't climbing or belaying. It was a contented and tired



Kim on "Fire Bug Pete" – Froggatt

lot that headed back to Bryce's to create dinner, with the eclectic array of food people had brought – pasta, burritos, blue cheese & walnut salad, followed by chocolate cake. We watched a few climbing DVDs and hit the sack around 10pm.

Sunday brought another fine day, and after indulging on a decent caffeine fix we headed off to Sheridan Hills. Sharon checked in with the farmer for permission and he said, "You've got a great day for it – enjoy." Although it can seem like an annoyance at times, just taking those few extra minutes to check in and get permission from the landowner is essential to ensure continued access to wonderful climbing sites. Don't take it for granted!

Sharon and I set up a couple of top ropes and then got on with some lead climbing for ourselves. For those of you who haven't been to Sheridan's – it is a little gem. We had an enjoyable time with climbs on Crow's Nest Pinnacle, Flying Cove Buttress and Chunderosa Buttress 1. There is a good range of grades and while many of the original routes have been re-bolted, keep a few bolt-hangers in your chalk bag (or small wires) as there are still a few carrot/naked bolts on some of the routes. There are lots of wonderful pockets and they are frequently home to bird's nests. A small baby bird fell out of a nest near Dead Cow Groove, but was safely reinstated before we left.

It had been many years since I had last climbed at Sheridan's and **Terrapin (16) on Meteora Buttress was too tempting, so ShiChang, Rob and I had a climb on it before we headed back to Bryce's to collect our bags, pack the cars and begin the drive home.

A few "firsts" were recorded during the weekend – ShiChang's first lead fall, Katy's first climbing in New Zealand, Shna's first lead in New Zealand, Rob's first time climbing at Wharepapa, Kim and Rini's first lead climbs at Sheridan's, and Bridget's first flat tyre.

A good weekend was had by all. When's the next one?



Katy belaying ShiChang – Froggatt

Mount Hopeless, Nelson Lakes, 19-21 January 2013

Dan Pringle

Trip participants: Colin Rolfe, Mark Hearfield, James Flannery, Dan Pringle. (On the SW ridge of Hopeless we took out our rope just to abseil one 11m vertical section instead of scrambling down to a ramping ledge traverse. Rock crux grade 12 (ish?) exiting chimney to get through steepest section at the base of the summit pyramid.)

Needing a fitness trip, I drafted a list of people and places and sent out an all points bulletin a week before Wellington Anniversary Weekend, hoping someone would be keen on Kehu in Nelson Lakes.

James was fresh back at work after a decent break down south and stoked to have someone at work to share his excitement about a walk-in climb of Aspiring with mountain running guru Colin Rolfe. Colin was keen for a Nelson Lakes trip, and had already lined up Mark who I knew from multi-sport circles.

"So what size is your pack?"

"I reckon I'll get it down to my 35 litre day pack."

"Ye-yeah. Footwear?"

"I need some time in boots, and there is some climbing, so I'm going for three season leather boots."

"Hmm. Um. Well, we're not going ultra light. Suppose that's okay."

The uncertainty of shooting for a light and fast approach to new terrain. The cautious apprehension of a trip with new people.

Back in the dark ages before CamelBaks, one square meals and caffeinated gels, Colin was posting record times in the Tararuas fuelled by plastic bags of rice pudding in instant coffee. With truck driving exploits to match, what was I letting myself in for?

Well, what we had was a cracker of a three-day jaunt in Nelson Lakes National Park taking in Cupola, Hopeless, Angelus and Robert Ridge.

We romped around the lake and up the beautiful Travers Valley to Cupola Hut by mid afternoon Saturday. Three stars for great condition, the view of Hopeless, and a new box fire perfect for heating up pizza and drying out saturated rain gear. Handy if 'light afternoon rain' comes in a little heavy. We had turned back at about 2,000m on Cupola in deteriorating visibility and strengthening wind and rain.

In beautiful weather the next day we traversed Mt Hopeless via the SW ridge and down the trampers' route to Hopeless Hut. The undoubted climbing highlight was the steep section of the summit pyramid immediately above the ridge. A bit daunting from the ridge, the steep orange rock here was easily the best on the route.

Climbers descending the snow slope below us turned out to be Lorraine Johns and Simon Bell returning from the summit via the Hopeless Creek Route, and we rolled back to Hopeless Hut together. Lorraine and Colin seemed equally pleased to find another Nelson Lakes aficionado and starting rattling off peaks, huts, tracks and nutting out the 21 peaks over 2,000m included in the 21 peaks in 21 days challenge. With the hut full, we were two in the wood shed and two under the stars.

Enjoying light packs, an afterglow from the day before and the easy camaraderie of a well-matched group, we went out via Sunset saddle, Mt Angelus, Robert Ridge and Bushline Hut. Three guys from the Swiss orienteering team left as we rolled into Angelus Hut. They'd just posted a time of 35 minutes hut to peak. Next time you're in there, don't be surprised to see a wide-eyed bushman in a truckie's singlet trying to better it!

Nelson Lakes really is a superb alpine area – not just a southern version of the Tararuas with Lakes, or a lower country cousin of the Kaikouras. If you haven't been before – or lately – take a look at the tramping and climbing options for the next three-day weekend. Air New Zealand might even fly you to where your ticket says.



High Alpine Skills Course

Sharron Came

On a blistering hot Canterbury afternoon I was dropped off at Matt's place where I met up with the Christchurch contingent heading to the NZAC High Alpine Skills Course (HASC). Matt's dad Rod had kindly lent us his van, by the look of his garage he could have outfitted us with all the kit we needed as well! The van turned out to be something of a Godsend, especially on the return journey when we managed to squeeze six people plus packs including all Jorin's worldly possessions (he was jumping on a plane back to the Netherlands the next day) into the vehicle.

I was the only North Islander on the course but my southern counterparts were very relaxed, friendly and helpful and I quickly felt right at home. The HASC is now a summer fixture thanks to Pat Deavoll who organised three of them along with some advanced courses. The courses are a fantastic, relatively low cost way for people with some alpine climbing experience to consolidate and grow their skills in the bigger mountains of the Mt Cook region. Each HASC is run over six days – typically you fly up to Barron Saddle and walk back over the Sealy range to Mueller and down to Mt Cook Village. Each course has a mix of eight students and two professional instructors/guides. Our guides were Gary Kuehn and Rob Dunn and they made a great team patiently teaching us a wide range of skills and imparting on us some of their vast knowledge and experience.

After some rope work in Mt Cook village we flew up to Barron Saddle and spent the next five days going over mountaineering fundamentals ranging from the use of ice axe and crampons, self arresting and glacier travel through to pitched climbing on rock and snow and soft snow and rock anchors. We also managed to fit in plenty of route and weather assessment and alpine bivvying on the journey back to the village.

Highlights for me included pitching up the snow slopes on Mt Darby, climbing most of the way up Montgomery before high winds saw us affect a strategic retreat and bivvying at the Annette Plateau wind scoop. Not sure I should admit it, but I also enjoyed watching the many kamikaze ice climbing attempts on the rotten ice near the wind scoop.

Gary and Rob taught us loads of things but for me a few things stood out:

- Be aware. When you are not on a rope you are soloing. Your feet are your anchors. Behave accordingly. Re-reading Dan's report from the 2012 course, the technical term for this is "don't f***ing fall in the mountains".



- Keep your office tidy! If you carry your slings and rock rack in a messy jumble you can expect at best to waste valuable time trying to locate the item you need when you need it and at worst to trip over said items.
- Climbing is a team sport. Look after your partner. Stick together and check how they are going. Chocolate is an excellent bonding agent (actually I already knew that bit).
- Have an open mind. It doesn't matter how many times you go over the basic skills you can always learn something new and it can be from anyone around you not just the instructor. I learnt lots from my climbing partners who were patient, supportive, funny and exceptionally generous with their knowledge – we had a different partner each day. I learnt lots from my own and other people's mistakes and from the excellent questions people asked.
- Anticipation and personal responsibility are crucial. This applies not only to preparation, route finding and climbing decisions but also to gear and clothing selection. One of my weaknesses is that I am inefficient at regulating my temperature and inclined to whinge about it. I learnt some new tricks for addressing this that I will find very useful for tramping as well as climbing.

By the time we made the trip back to Christchurch my goals for the course had been achieved: I'd had a fun and challenging week in the hills and survived on minimal sleep, I was feeling more confident about my technical proficiency and I'd gotten some fresh ideas for teaching basic alpine skills that I hope to utilise on the introductory alpine courses run by my tramping club. A few days later I managed to climb the west ridge of Mt Sefton – as good a testimony as any to the value of the course. The best way to reinforce your learning is to get out in the hills and apply it.

Big thanks to Pat Deavoll at NZAC, Gary and Rob our instructors, and the rest of the course participants for a great week in the mountains.





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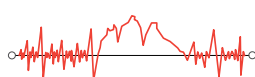
Special focus topic: Nepal rescue program, 29 May 2014

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Notices

New club fund

The Expedition Capital Fund has been set up with a substantial donation from the profits of the last Ice and Mixed Festival thanks to organiser, Daniel Joll. On-going donations to this fund will be used to build up a capital base for expeditions of the future. It is separate from the General Fund that will continue to be used for annual grants. Donors can now chose the funding option they prefer and automatic payments to the fund are also accepted. For more information see: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/donation/expedition-capital-fund>

Joy of the Mountains – John Harrison biography

NZAC has just received four copies of this title, signed by the author John Wilson. We would like to give individual NZAC members the chance to purchase these before advertising online.

If you wish to purchase one you can do so here: <http://alpineclub.org.nz/product/joy-of-the-mountains-a-climbers-life> (please put SIGNED COPY in the comments section), or contact Margaret 03 3777595 at the National Office.

I imagine the signed copies will go quickly, so orders will be processed as if you still want a book even if the signed ones have gone (unless you state otherwise).

2013 Calendar Special

The 2013 NZAC Photographic Calendars are nearing the end of their stock and so have gone on sale for just \$10ea including postage.

Order online here: <http://alpineclub.org.nz/product/nzac-alpine-calendar/2013>

Hanger Price-drop

NZAC have dropped the price to members of our 10mm hangers (now just \$5.50) and 10mm ring hangers (\$12) – plus p&p.

See the online shop for purchasing: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/shop/hangers-bolts?category=28>

Vertigo editor required!

Work commitments mean that the current editor of the Wellington Section's newsletter won't be able to stay in this role for much longer, so we're looking for someone to take this on. It isn't a particularly onerous job, and doesn't require any specialised software (though that's always handy). Please contact Steve, the current editor, at stephennui@yahoo.co.uk to find out more.

Wellington Section 2012/13 contacts list

Position	Name	Email alias*	Phone
Chairperson	Dan Pringle	chairperson	
Vice Chair	Vincent Zintzen	vicechair	
Secretary	Bridget Janse	secretary or CM2	04 293 6351 (h), or 021 133 8237
Treasurer	Matt Knarston	treasurer	
National Rep	vacant		
Patron	John Nankervis		
Trips	vacant	Trips	
Other Committee Members	Simon Williamson		
	Julian Davidson		
	John Yu		
Other Roles:			
Gear	vacant	gear	
Personal Locator Beacons	vacant	PLB	
Instruction Coordinator	vacant		
Instruction - AIC	vacant		
Instruction - Rock	vacant		
Library	Joke Meerkens	library	
Newsletter Editor	Steve Minchin	newsletter or SM	
Rock Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	drill or KF	
Website	John Yu	webmaster	
* Email address is: alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz eg. secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz			
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary			
Any media queries should be directed to:			
03 3777 595	National Executive Officer	Sam Newton	sam@alpineclub.org.nz



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